

The Year of the Two Winters

In Kamen Brod the year of the two winters carries one number in the civil register and another in the baptismal register, and the difference is not a mistake. Scholars who write about the year, when they can agree where to look for it, call the difference a curiosity. In the town it is not a curiosity. There are people in the town a year older in one book than in the other, who have been so all their lives, and know why.

The First Winter

The first winter was ordinary and is remembered for it. Snow came in the week it was expected, lay the depth the roofs were built for, and went in March like a guest who knows the hour. The Cherna closed above the ford — the old maps call it Singer's Ford — and opened again, and the ice went down the river in the usual manner, shouldering.

The town was then what it is now, only more so. It had a church, a town hall, a school, a mill, and two barbers who did not speak to each other, for a reason the town no longer possessed but continued to respect. It had a market on Thursdays, at which the same geese were sold back and forth until they were owed more than they were worth. It had a railway station at which the 17:40 arrived at 17:40, the railway keeping Vienna time and being, in consequence, the only institution in the district that did not observe local disputes. And it had a meteorological station, third class, which stood behind the post office and consisted of Lazar, the instruments, and a fence to keep goats from the instruments. Lazar read the thermometers at seven, at two, and at nine, and entered what they said. This was all the Bureau asked of him, and more, as it proved, than it wanted.

Records were kept twice. Births, marriages, and deaths went into the civil register at the town hall, where the registrar ruled his lines against a straightedge, and into the baptismal register at the church, where Father Yosif ruled nothing and had never lost an entry. The two books agreed so exactly that the town considered them one book kept in two places.

The thaw came when it always came, and the storks returned to the chimney of the mill on the day the school expected them.

The Summer

At Easter, Andon asked for Tsona and was accepted on both sides. He had the orchard above the ford and she had the good hands of that family, and nobody in

the town could think of an objection, which was itself remarked on. The banns were set for September, after the harvest, in the usual order of things.

The summer was hot. In the first week of July the cherries, the wheat, the plums, and the walnuts came ripe together, which is not a thing that happens, and the old women went quiet and put every pair of hands in the town into the fields. The harvest was done in three weeks. Nobody was told why it had to be, and nobody asked. Tsona and Andon were put to the same row.

The storks left on the twentieth of July. It was noted.

The bees worked late and badly. The second hay was got in dry. Tsona's dress was made in the last of July, of the good cloth, against September, and hung in the wardrobe on the north wall.

On the feast of the Transfiguration the weather was clear, and nobody afterward claimed otherwise. That night it turned still, in the way a room goes still when someone is about to speak, and by morning there was snow to the windowsills, and it was August.

The Second Winter

It did not melt. The first day the town treated it as an event, the second as an inconvenience, and by the fourth it had stopped being either, because the snow fell with the patience of December.

The melons were dug out from under it, cold to the heart. The Cherna closed at the ford in the last week of August, and boys slid on it in their summer shirts until their mothers reached them. Wolves came down in September and found the flocks still out; the losses are in the district books. The beekeeper fed his hives their own honey back, an arrangement he declined to explain. At the school, where the curriculum is fixed by the calendar, the class covered the customs of harvest; for the practical, they looked out the window.

Because the harvest had come in July, it had been gathered in July, and the town went into the snow with full barns and no explanation. The old women accepted thanks without surprise. What could not be kept in the barn was put up in glass, that autumn and all that winter. The year of the two winters was eaten for a decade. There are said to be jars still.

The procession for the Dormition went out as appointed, with sheaves, between drifts. Attendance is recorded as complete.

In the second week of the snow, Andon's father, who had made the match, died sitting up, with the harvest already in — a death the town called tidy. The

family did not call it anything. The mourning was reckoned, in the usual way, from the day: a year.

In the tavern the year acquired its factions. One held that this was a second winter, entire and additional; the other, that it was the same winter returned for something it had forgotten. Men who would not drink together over the question drank apart over it for thirty years. The two barbers were found to be on the same side of it, for the first time in memory, and did not speak of that either.

Lazar read the thermometers at seven, at two, and at nine, and entered what they said, and sent the readings to the Bureau, and the Bureau sent them back stamped RETURNED FOR CORRECTION. He sent them again. They came back again. The third time, he wrote under the stamp that the readings had been corrected in no particular, and sent them, and kept the carbons. The difficulty, as it emerged, was not meteorological. A winter has costs — boots, stoves, the school's wood, the army's coal — and the Treasury declined to incur a second winter in one budget. The Bureau's finding was therefore hail, prolonged.

The Bureau's inspector, Manov, second class, arrived on the 17:40 in a straw hat, the capital's position being that it was August. He stood in the snow on the platform for some time. His report, preserved in the *Bulletin of the Third-Class Stations*, is one sentence: *It is snow*. He was thanked and not promoted. He was also not recalled, the capital seeing no need of an inspector where there was no winter, and so he wintered in the town like everyone else, and by spring had married the miller's sister, which the town had seen coming since the platform.

A theatrical company, caught on the wrong side of the ford, wintered in the town as well and played its repertory through twice. By the second time the town knew the plays better than the company and prompted from the floor, and the company, to its credit, took the corrections. There is a wedding in the third play. It was played both times, without cuts, and nobody looked at anybody. A photographer traveling with the company made plates of the snow on the melon fields, for proof. The plates are in the district museum, and they look like winter, which was never the dispute.

A wedding wants roads, and guests, and a priest with his mind on it, and it does not want fresh mourning. The banns were read once, as appointed, and suspended. The dress stayed in the wardrobe, now with a sprig of basil, and Tsona changed the sprig at the new moon, every month, which the household saw and did not remark. Andon crossed the ford on the ice on Sundays and

walked with her, at a distance nobody could fault. If either of them minded the waiting, it was not seen.

The snow fell through September, and through October, and into the months in which it would have been expected anyway, at which point, it was generally agreed, it at least stopped being strange.

The Question of the Year

The civil year ends, by the Reckoning Act, on the thirty-first of December, and the registrar ended it: ruled the line, carried the totals, and opened the new page with the new year's number at the top, because the law does not ask the weather.

The church was not able to be so brisk.

Father Yosif gave his position from the church steps rather than the pulpit, holding that the matter was administration, and administration did not belong in the liturgy. His position was this. A winter is one thing. It may pause; it does not divide. And a year comes in with its winter: the winter is the year, arriving. The snow that had begun after the Transfiguration and the snow falling now were one winter, and that winter was the next year, come early, for reasons not given to us. Everything since the Transfiguration therefore stood in the new year. He corrected the baptismal register accordingly, back through August, in a fine hand, and the children born under the snow were thereby born in one year by the state and in the next by God, which is the arithmetic those houses have carried ever since.

It was objected, in the tavern, that by this rule every year should begin at its first snow. Father Yosif agreed, and said the other years had come near enough.

The consequences came on like weather, steadily, and without regard for whose fields they fell on. The tax on hearths, assessed annually, was assessed once; it was observed at the town hall that nobody came forward to pay it twice. Promissory notes falling due *in the new year* fell due in January or had fallen due in August, depending on the faith of the holder, and were litigated for a generation; the court in the district seat, asked to fix the date of the new year, found the question political and fixed nothing. A man whose name day fell in the autumn kept it twice that year or not at all, according to his register, and either way drank.

The town hall kept the state's New Year, which was attended by those employed to attend it. The church kept none, Father Yosif observing that by his

count the new year was four months old and a feast for it would be late.

It should be recorded that the town itself, for daily use, kept a third reckoning that needed no ruling: before the snow, and after it. It served. It serves still, in houses where the other two are not spoken of together.

Through all of it the railway kept Vienna time, and the 17:40 arrived at 17:40, both winters, every day the line was open. The town, whose every other clock had taken a side, took to setting itself by the train. The habit outlived the question, and then the question's cause, and is by now simply a thing the town does.

For Tsona and Andon the question sat close to home. The banns had been read once, in September, and September, by Father Yosif's own ruling, stood in the new year; and the new year was barely open before the mourning for Andon's father lay across it, until the following August; and the church does not marry across mourning. Father Yosif worked it every way it went, and it went, every way, against them. He was known to be sorry, and known also not to bend. They would be married, he said, when the mourning was out and the years were level, and the leveling of years was not parish work. The mourning, at least, had a date.

The Winter That Did Not Come

The following winter did not come. December passed green. In January the cattle were out, and the Cherna ran open the whole month, and did not close at the ford once, that season, nor for much of the next. The storks came back at the usual date. The Bulletin gives the season as exceptionally clement.

The town had a plainer account. The winter had been spent in advance, and when its date came round there was nothing left to fall.

The ford being water again, Andon crossed on Sundays by the bridge at the mill, which is longer. The sprig in the wardrobe was changed at the new moon, as before.

By the time the mourning was out, Father Yosif no longer left the parish house. The district sent a priest for the feasts, who would not touch the question of the year, holding it to be Yosif's. Father Yosif died in November, before the green December that would have been his proof. The whole town walked behind him, both counts of it.

His successor, asked for the church's position on the year, said that he had no opinions, only predecessors, and kept the register exactly as he found it.

Lazar checked the instruments, found them honest, and began the only book

of his life: *On the Expenditure of Winters*, an essay in the conservation of seasons, with tables. He printed it at his own cost. It was reviewed once, at length and, it seems, warmly, in a foreign journal, in a language he could not read. He kept the pages cut anyway.

In the spring a circular came down from the Synod, *On the Completion of Years*, which closed the matter without once mentioning it. The years were declared level. Nobody was moved back.

Carried Forward

Twenty years on, the boys born between the Transfiguration and the New Year were called to the colors by the state's count, a year before their mothers held them old enough. The tribunals sat with both registers open, heard the priest and the registrar with equal courtesy, and ruled, in every case, for the register that had soldiers in it. Those of that cohort who emigrated gave, on the ships' manifests, whichever year served, and were believed, the sea not keeping registers.

The district history treats the year in a footnote, its author confessing that he could not settle the date. The footnote is longer than the chapter.

Lazar's instruments are in the district museum, labeled, and still fenced, by tradition, against goats.

Tsona and Andon were married in the spring the years were declared level, a year and two seasons after the September that had been appointed. The successor read the banns their remaining two Sundays and married them himself, observing that on the question of the year he still held no opinions; the Synod had leveled the years, and for the wedding he had a predecessor's word to follow. The dress came out of the wardrobe. The basil in it was fresh.

At the feast they opened jars of the summer that had stood between the winters — plums of that July, put up in glass and carried through everything. They had kept; they tasted of July. Which July was not entered anywhere.